SWA2 (2026 Summer)

Reading material - Section 1

1.1 Notes on this assignment

The aim of this unit is to help you develop a critical understanding of the main debates in contemporary social theory, and to apply those debates to concrete cases. You will be expected to read roughly forty pages a week, attend the seminar prepared to discuss the reading in detail, and write one short response paper per fortnight. Assessment is by a 3,000 word essay submitted at the end of the term, plus a ten minute presentation.

1.2 Reading list

1. Bourdieu, P. (1984) Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste.
2. Giddens, A. (1991) Modernity and Self-Identity. Cambridge: Polity.
3. Sassen, S. (2014) Expulsions: Brutality and Complexity in the Global Economy.

1.3 Seminar questions

- How does Bourdieu explain the reproduction of social inequality?
- What does Giddens mean by the reflexive project of the self?
- Where do you see the limits of these accounts for non-Western societies?